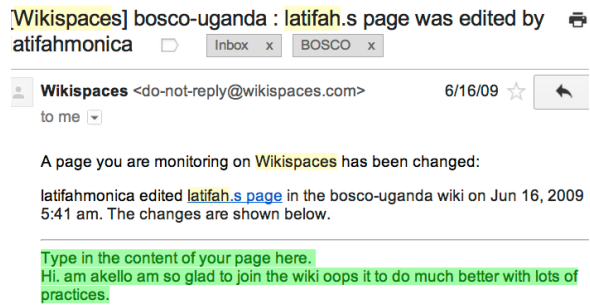


I first met Latifah as administrator and subscriber to the BOSCO-Uganda Wikispaces site. Her determination was evident from her first post; the remarkable circumstances that gave birth to that determination emerged only later. BOSCO's web 2.0 training had found an eager student in Latifah. She quickly emerged as a leader of



Notification of Latifah's 1st post to the BOSCO wiki



The computer Latifah managed in Coope

her Coope site, managing training around one highly-valued computer in a rented storefront. When she wasn't training others, Latifah (Akello, Monica... the Acholi don't make a surname distinction) began to share about her life, online for the world to read. I began to interact with her remotely on some technical issues, and became captivated by her story.

Like everyone she knew, Latifah had had been a victim of a brutal civil war, inheriting the aftermath of 20 years of cultural scouring. Like tens of thousands of Acholi children, she had been kidnapped and enslaved by the Lord's Resistance Army. As she indicated, much of her experience was too painful to describe, a reluctance that must be measured against what she could bring herself to share: of being beaten to within an inch of her life for refusing to beat a boy to death (his crime: attempting to return home); of forcible wedlock, in a group of young women all of whom faced a common life with promise of a common death if any of them escaped; of surviving and escaping through a government attack on the rebels; of returning home to shame and marginalization; of young teen pregnancy. But she also told of a father who loved her and urged her to take every challenge in life as an opportunity. And so

she has.



Latifah welcoming me to BOSCO's Coope site

In March of 2010, after months of online interaction, we met 'again for the first time'—this time face-to-face—as I toured the BOSCO Coope community site that continued to elect Latifah as their leader. Monica showed me their one computer, one printer, and one solar-charged battery used to power both this hardware and a few small entrepreneurial activities

(like cell phone charging) with what surplus power remained. In her attempts to train and engage the youth of her village, the scarcity of computing resources was a challenge. Latifah was helping Coope make the most of the opportunity.

During this time, Latifah continued to post regularly. Writing about what she knew, she told of her hopes for law school to advocate for women's rights, and shared at length about the cultural practices surrounding childbirth in traditional Acholi culture. Just this summer, she reflected on the press of isolation and hopelessness in the aftermath of the civil war, but how information and communications technology (or ICT as much of the world refers to computing) has been a source of hope in the lives of young people in the BOSCO-Uganda network. Latifah lives that hope. She summarized her intentions in one of her very many memorable posts: *This knowledge that have got from BOSCO i will always use it by posting in the Wikispaces, keep the togetherness, i will always try to work hard so that my life change and the life of my child change too and to always train the youth both sexes but i will also emphasize on the ladies who seem disadvantageous and i will make sure they learn the web 2.0 so that they can say all they have in their hearts so that they are relief from the pain by saying it out.!!!!!!!!!!!!!!*

I met Latifah a third time, quite unexpectedly. Having taken employment in Gulu, she was volunteering in a new site, BOSCO's Bardege Library, where I was installing a computer classroom this past August. One of four such installations, this equipment was donated by HP as part of an Accenture supported [partnership](#) between BOSCO and the University of Notre Dame's Initiative for Global Development. We are collaborating to create ecosystems where young people can receive entrepreneurial and ICT training in the presence of sufficient solar power to support the connectivity and catalyze entrepreneurial uses of renewable energy. During the past year as this partnership emerged, I often remembered Latifah's account of the hope that a single solar-powered computer brought to Coope. In many respects—by responding to the opportunity to learn, training others, telling her story, and sharing local needs—Latifah brought these computers to Northern Uganda. In the hands of determined young leaders like her, they will be instruments of hope and opportunity for many others.



Students in the Bardege Library in Gulu gather around a cluster of energy-efficient HP thin client PCs, powered by a local solar micro-grid.